Rasikananda Deva Gosvami

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Shyamananda's Foremost Disciple

Shyamananda Prabhu — a disciple of Hridaya Chaitanya of Ambika, trained in Vrindavana under Srila Jiva Gosvami — returned to Utkala (Orissa) and in the lands bordering Bengal gained countless disciples. The most eminent and the closest of them all was Rasikananda. His biographers honour him as Rasikananda Deva Gosvami or Sri Rasikananda Deva; a poet of his own circle calls him Rasika-deva, Rasikendra, Rasika-shekhara — “the crown of rasikas” — or simply “the son of Achyuta.”

The earliest and fullest account of him is a Bengali poem, the “Sri Rasika-mangala.” It was composed by Gopijana-vallabha Dasa, son of Rasamaya, one of the Vaishnavas close to Rasikananda; their family were gopas, cowherds, and the whole household, the poet says, “dwelt at Rasika's feet.” He was told to write it by the kirtana singer Tulasi Dasa and by “Rasika-shekhara of Bedhapala”; according to the colophon, the poem was begun in 1658 and finished in 1660, some eight years after Rasikananda's departure, and the author more than once remarks that he writes “what the son of Achyuta himself told me.”[1]

He also bore a second name, Murari. Narahari Chakravarti writes in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (15.27–28): in the village of Rayani dwelt the renowned son of Achyuta, who bore two names, Sri Rasikananda and Sri Murari; people knew him as Rasika-Murari, and from an early age he was versed in all the scriptures. The “Rasika-mangala” says that at his naming he was given the principal name “Sri Rasika,” while people called him Murari; it is as Rasika-Murari that he is most often remembered.[2]

Homeland and Family

Rasikananda appeared in the year 1512 of the Shaka era (1590), in the village of Rayani (Rohini, Rauni) on the Suvarnarekha River. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (15.21–23) and the “Rasika-mangala” place Rayani in the land of Mallabhumi and say that the Suvarnarekha flows northward there, while beside the village runs the river Dolanga; in the midst of the town stood a fort, the ruler's seat. The “Rasika-mangala” also names the day: the eighteenth day of the solar month of Tula, the night of the Dipavali festival, when the amavasya was ending and the bright pratipad beginning — a Sunday, in the third watch of the night; the poet even gives the infant's horoscope.[3] The Suvarnarekha winds along the present border of Bengal and Orissa, and in those days Medinipur belonged to the kingdom of Orissa. The land is ancient: according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (15.23–25) and the “Rasika-mangala,” in Barajita, a village beside Rayani on the bank of the Dolanga, Ramachandra, the son of Dasharatha, stayed for a time in exile with Lakshmana and Sita, and there He installed the Shiva-linga Rameshvara.

His father, Achyuta (Achyutananda, Achyutadeva), was the ruler of Mallabhumi; Rayani is called his capital. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (15.26) says that he, the ruler of that land, delighted in caring for his subjects and was pure in conduct. The “Rasika-mangala” adds that, calm, restrained and patient, he served the brahmanas, was devoted to the holy name, and was kind and courteous to all. He had, according to the same poem, several wives and many sons; Rasika's elder brother was Kashinatha Raya. The mother, Bhavani, was renowned as a truly faithful wife, and the whole family lived in bhakti. She was the daughter of Haladhara Pattanayaka, a man of a noble karana family who had fled Cuttack from the oppression of the yavanas and, having lost everything, came to Rayani; Achyuta saw the girl in the house of Gopi Mandala, asked for her hand and arranged the wedding himself. The poet says that the parents received this son as the fruit of their austerities, and the son, in the words of the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (15.29), was “most skilled in serving his mother and father.”[4]

Achyuta's family was, according to the “Rasika-mangala,” “a noble karana family”; one biography explains that Achyutananda was an Oriya, and that the karanas correspond to the kayasthas among Bengalis.[5] But a Vaishnava is beyond the modes of material nature and is not judged by caste: as the same biographer explains, father and son were born among the karanas in order to bless that caste.

Childhood

Even before his birth there lived in that region Dayal-dasi Thakurani, “a devotee of Chaitanya,” who had a temple of her own; Achyuta always served her. While Bhavani carried her son, Dayal-dasi told her of Krishna, and, like Prahlada, the child heard those stories in the womb. At the ear-piercing ceremony she fainted as soon as she saw the infant: “It was as if I saw the Deity of Gopala.” She foretold that he would deliver living beings and, by Chaitanya's command, spread prema-bhakti in Utkala down to the chandalas — and in her mercy she whispered the name “Hare Krishna” into his ear.

As an infant he wept with tears and trembling whenever he heard Krishna's name, and gazed steadily at whoever spoke it. At the rite of his first rice, from all the things laid out before him he seized the “Srimad-Bhagavata.” He played with other children at Krishna's pastimes from the “Bhagavata,” offered sweets to Tulasi and gave out prasada; from an early age he would sit in meditation, chanting the maha-mantra for two or three hours, and from then on he chanted a lakh of names daily, touching no food until he had completed the number.

From his earliest years Rasikananda was an example of devotion to Krishna. His father invited learned pandits to teach him, and the boy, as handsome as he was gifted, excelled in every subject. The “Rasika-mangala” names his teachers: he learned his letters from Vasudeva and grammar from Mimamsa-mandana Bhattacharya, who said of him, “This is no ordinary human being”; then he studied with the physician Balabhadra and others, and heard the “Bhagavata” from Jagannatha Mishra and Hari Dube, explaining it in the manner of Sridhara Svami and interpreting a single verse in many ways. Yet worldly learning held no attraction for him: whatever he studied, he found in it one conclusion — service to Hari.

Once, hearing of the gopis' separation from Krishna, the youth wandered in the forest for seven days without food, and only Hari Dube could console him. Home lost all charm for him. To his father, who promised to give him whatever he wished, he replied: “Worldly wealth is false; Krishna is true, His pastimes are true, Vrindavana is true, the gopis are true. Worship Krishna, father.”

Marriage

Seeing that his son was drawn to renunciation, Achyuta married him as he entered youth. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (15.30–31) names his wife Ichchha and says that she was rich in virtues. According to the “Rasika-mangala,” she was Ichchhadevi, daughter of Balabhadra Dasa, the ruler of Hijli: Achyuta had rescued Balabhadra when the subadar of Medinipur detained him for arrears of revenue, and Balabhadra, seeing Rasika, promised him his daughter. From childhood Ichchhadevi had worshipped a murti of Krishna and prayed for a husband like Krishna, so that “birth after birth she might be his maidservant.” Balabhadra died suddenly, but his brother Sadashiva kept the promise, and the wedding was held in Hijli. Later, at her initiation, Shyamananda gave her the name Shyamadasi, and by that name she is known as Rasikananda's wife. For a time Rasikananda lived in the village of Ghatshila (Ghantshila) near the Suvarnarekha — the place where, by tradition, the Pandavas rested during their forest exile.[6]

A Guru Named from Above

The young man's heart was seeking a true guru who would lead him on the confidential path. Even before they met, Srila Jiva Gosvami, seeing off the cart of books from Vrindavana, said to Shyamananda: “Achyutananda's son, named Murari Dasa, has set his heart on your shelter” (“Prema-vilasa,” 13.47). The “Rasika-mangala” tells that in Vrindavana Madana-Gopala Himself appeared to Shyamananda at night and said: “My dearest devotee Rasika-Murari — instruct him in Utkala”; He gave the same command to Jiva Gosvami, and Jiva told Shyamananda: “Rasika-Murari is very dear to the Lord.” It was hard for Shyamananda to leave Vraja, but, taking leave of Jiva and the Vaishnavas of Vrindavana, he set out for Utkala with Kishora, Shyamadasa and his brother Prasada-dasa. In Agra the Mughal head of the town threw them into prison, but, punished from above, he repented, and Shyamananda asked of him only one thing — to serve the Vaishnavas.

How Rasikananda learned who his guru was, the sources tell differently. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (15.32–39), one day in Ghatshila Murari sat alone, wondering: whose disciple am I to become? And a voice came from the sky: “Do not worry: here you will become a disciple of Sri Shyamananda.” Hearing this, Rasika-Murari rejoiced and began to repeat Shyamananda's name as a mantra. His longing grew from moment to moment, and at the name of Shyamananda tears streamed from his eyes. He spent almost the whole night in anxiety, and only toward morning did sleep overtake him. In a dream he saw Shyamananda, wondrous in the beauty of every limb, who said to him with a smile, “At daybreak you will find me here,” and vanished. Rasikananda was filled with great joy.

The “Rasika-mangala” tells it otherwise. The youth used to wander alone in the forests by the Suvarnarekha with the “Bhagavata,” the holy name and kirtana, and one day he sat down at the spot where the Pandavas had rested; closing his eyes, he chanted the holy name, pining in separation from Krishna. At dusk Krishna Himself appeared before him — dark and beautiful, in His threefold bending pose, the flute at His lips — and said: “Listen, Rasika: your teacher is Shyamananda. My beloved has taken birth in the form of Shyamananda; giving prema-bhakti, he will deliver everyone. By serving him you will attain My feet, and I shall always be in your heart.”[7] Rasika opened his eyes, saw Krishna and fell at His feet — and Krishna vanished. Rasika lay there senseless till morning, until his relatives found him. He told no one what he had seen; heedless of food and sleep, he worshipped Shyamananda ceaselessly in his mind: “When shall I see that moonlike face?”[8]

The two sources also describe the meeting each in its own way. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (15.40–46), at daybreak the wise Rasika, saying nothing to anyone, began to watch the road. And then, a little way off, Shyamananda appeared. He came joyfully, surrounded by disciples — Sri Kishora Dasa and others — shining like the sun, a smile on his face, holding beads on which he kept ceaseless count of Krishna's names, and, beside himself with prema, swaying as he went, he sang the names of Krishna-Chaitanya and Nityananda. According to the “Rasika-mangala,” Shyamananda, coming to Rayani and learning that Rasika was in Ghantshila, went there and entered the raja's assembly, where a brahmana was reading the “Bhagavata” and Rasika was questioning the pandits on its meaning. Each recognised the other in his heart and, not yet knowing each other's names, they wept; and when the raja withdrew, Rasika was left alone with him. In both accounts Rasika-Murari falls to the ground, touching his feet, and Shyamananda lovingly raises and embraces him; according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” he bathed him with his tears, and according to the “Rasika-mangala,” he said: “You are an associate of Krishna, the son of Achyuta; by Krishna's command I have come from Vrindavana to see you.” Rasikananda felt himself blessed and could not take his eyes from the beauty of his Prabhu.

Rasikananda brought his guru to his house, washed his feet, honoured him with fragrances and flowers, and surrendered himself, his family and his children at his feet; Shyamananda took his little daughter Devaki on his lap. Remembering Dayal-dasi's prophecy, Rasika asked: “Give me the names and mantras of Radha and Krishna.” After the preliminary rites, on an auspicious day, Shyamananda initiated him

into the mantra of Radha and Krishna and, accepting him as a disciple, offered him at the feet of Nityananda and Chaitanya; and Rasika-Murari was overwhelmed with prema, tears pouring ceaselessly from his eyes (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 15.47–49).

Then, according to the “Rasika-mangala,” Rasika said to his wife: “If you are truly my beloved, take instruction from Shyamananda, leaving aside fear of the family, shame and custom.” Shyamananda whispered the mantra to her, gave her the name Shyamadasi, dedicating her for life to Krishna's service, and told her: “Feed the Vaishnavas yourself; wherever you settle at my word, all treasures will be there.” And once in the raja's assembly, while all were listening to the “Bhagavata,” Shyamananda in anger struck Rasika twice with his foot; Rasika fell prostrate and said with tears: “Today my karma, good and bad, is destroyed; today I am free of the bonds of the world — through the blow I have gained both my Prabhu's feet.” Seeing such devotion, Shyamananda embraced him and wept.[9]

Why was the initiation into the worship of Radha and Krishna? Shyamananda's own guru, Hridaya Chaitanya, worshipped the Lord as a friend (sakhya-bhava). But in Vrindavana, in the company of the devotees of Vraja headed by Srila Jiva Gosvami, Shyamananda embraced the mood of conjugal love (madhurya-bhava) — and in that mood he instructed his disciple. The “Rasika-mangala” tells that Shyamananda spent the four months of the rains in Ghantshila: first they examined all the scriptures, and then in private he revealed to his disciple the confidential path — worship in the mood of the gopis, Vrindavana, the Yogapitha, Radha and Krishna on Their throne surrounded by the eight sakhis.

This whole story, one biographer remarks, shows that sincere prayer itself brings one to the guru.

Beside His Guru

According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (15.50–53), Rasikananda brought his Prabhu to Rayani, and there all were plunged into an ocean of sankirtana joy. Friends and relatives were invited; the whole village sang the holy names, came for Shyamananda's darshana and, struck by his explanation of the message of Gaura and Nityananda, took shelter of him. Shyamananda stayed there some days and made many disciples. Of the yogi Damodara and Shyamananda's other disciples the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (15.55–58, 15.62–66) tells: according to it, Shyamananda showed Damodara mercy after leaving Rayani. The “Rasika-mangala” says this happened in the village of Chakulia, when Shyamananda was on his way to Jagannatha and Rasika was accompanying him: the learned yogi Damodara Dasa, going to the river Kharva for his breathing exercises, saw in the forest Krishna on a throne and beside Him Shyamananda in the form of His beloved — and accepted initiation together with his family; Rasika himself had urged him to surrender. “The first two disciples by Shyamananda's mercy were these two — Rasika and Damodara,” the poet writes.[10] The great festival that Shyamananda held in the village of Dharenda together with Kishora, Murari, Damodara and others (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 15.60) is remembered to this day.

“Who could describe with a single mouth the guru-bhakti of Sri Rasika-Murari?” exclaims Narahari Chakravarti. Shyamananda tested Murari and, seeing how he conducted himself, was filled with great joy (15.51–52). Rasikananda himself travelled for a long time with his guru, never leaving his feet. He devoted himself to serving him with body, mind and heart — and so he was soon recognised as Shyamananda's foremost disciple, and later became a mighty preacher and a guru who gave initiation himself. “Disciples so devoted to their guru there never were and never will be,” says the “Rasika-mangala”: he honoured Shyamananda more than Krishna and carried out his every word, however hard; guru, Krishna and the Vaishnavas, the poet adds, he served as non-different. Whoever becomes a true disciple becomes a true teacher: a guru may have many “disciples” in name, but he passes his power only to one who has surrendered to him completely. Such was Rasikananda.

Once Shyamananda sent him a letter from Bara-Balarampura: “Come at once.” The letter found Rasika at his meal — the second mouthful of prasada was still in his hand. He rose, washed his hand in the Suvarnarekha and left immediately — alone, at nightfall, in the rain, in the dark, through a forest of tigers, rhinoceroses and elephants where no one went alone even by day — chanting “Hare Krishna.” Seeing his weary, drawn face, Shyamananda embraced him.

Afterwards, according to the “Rasika-mangala,” Rasika made a pilgrimage to Vraja. Shyamananda, setting out for Nilachala and from there for Mathura, had told him to stay at home for a while and then come. Rasika travelled through the forest country to Mathura, went round the twelve forests and at Govardhana bowed to Gopala Raya; there Krishna, appearing to him in the guise of a Vrajavasi, told him: “Go quickly to Utkala; My Shyamananda is waiting for you — see his feet in Mathura.” They met in Mathura; Rasika asked to stay on in Vraja, but Shyamananda answered: “We have both been ordered to go to Utkala.” On the way back they initiated Vishnudasa, named Rasamaya Dasa — the father of the future author of the poem.

The “Prema-vilasa” (19.105–109) preserves this incident. Once, when Shyamananda was in seclusion, Damodara came to him and saw his form shining brilliantly and a radiant sacred thread on his body. Just then Rasika and other devotees arrived and began to offer praises, and Shyamananda, concealing both the thread and his radiance, began nama-sankirtana. Other early sources tell that Narottama Thakura showed mercy to Rasika-Murari in Nrisimhapura: at the parting he stood to one side weeping, and Narottama embraced him with great affection (“Narottama-vilasa,” 4.229–230). When messengers came from Vrindavana, Murari Dasa washed their feet, and the guests said to each other, “As the guru, so the disciple — we have never seen the like”; guru and disciple wept, rolling on the ground, and at parting Murari Dasa gave the narrator a hundred coins for the journey back. “What a disciple of Shyamananda is Murari Dasa! Nowhere have I seen such faith in the service of the Vaishnavas,” the narrator writes (“Prema-vilasa,” 17.126–143).

He is remembered in Narahari's songs about Shyamananda as well, and the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (1.411) and the “Narottama-vilasa” (3.96) name him among Shyamananda's disciples in Utkala. When Shyamananda returned from Vana-Vishnupura to Utkala, “Sri Rasikananda and the others were filled with great joy” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 9.258).

According to the same sources, Rasikananda came from Utkala with Shyamananda to the great festival at Kheturi. Narottama brought him and Shyamananda's other disciples together with everyone and said to him affectionately: “My child, you will see to everything, so that no one is in any way slighted”; Rasikananda stood silent with joined palms, deeming himself blessed. With Purushottama, Kishora and others he had the provisions brought from their own land placed in Gauranga's storeroom and saw to the people who had come with them. When the Lord and His associates manifested at the festival, Rasikananda lay unconscious on the ground with the others; and before the departure everything that was to go with Shyamananda was entrusted to him (“Narottama-vilasa,” 6.157–174; 7.146; 8.352). He was also present at the great assembly where Virabhadra spoke, and at the farewell of the mahantas.[11]

Gopivallabhapura and the Service of Govinda

When Rasika's father left the world, quarrels broke out among the brothers. Rasika fed sadhus without regard to their birth, drank the water that had washed their feet and with his wife ate their remnants; his relatives reviled him for disgracing the family, and some abused the sadhus themselves. Then he said to Shyamadasi: “A Vaishnava is dearer to me than Krishna, and because of me they are reviled — I shall go.”[12] She answered: “Where you are, there am I; with you even the shade of a tree is good.” Taking only the family Deity — once seized by force by the Bhanja raja and recovered by Rasika himself — in nothing but the clothes they wore they went away to the Suvarnarekha, to a secluded part of Mallabhumi

called “the hidden Vrindavana,” where Rasika's elder brother Kashinatha Raya had founded the village of Kashipura. There they built a house and served sadhus by the hundred.

Shyamananda came, and Rasika asked him to name the Deity who had been in their house from of old. “Everyone will call Him Gopivallabha Raya,” Shyamananda replied, “and this village — Sri Gopivallabhapura. Here service to the sadhus and to Krishna will abound, and it will become as renowned as Vrindavana; here Govinda Himself will manifest, and the form that is seen in meditation all will see with their own eyes. The adhikari of this village will be Mother Shyamadasi, while Rasika, detached, will at my word wander ceaselessly to deliver souls” (“Rasika-mangala”). The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (15.81) says that in Gopivallabhapura Shyamananda “poured down a rain of prema and entrusted the service of Sri Govinda to Sri Rasika”; the “Prema-vilasa” (19.90) says the same.

Shyamananda installed the Deity of Sri Govindadeva — Radha-Govinda — in Gopivallabhapura, near the border of Orissa and Bengal, on the Bengal side. According to one biography, after the installation festival he left for Utkala, and the service of the Deity was entrusted to Rasikananda.[13] Rasikananda accepted it with the greatest care and gave himself to it entirely; the devotees were captivated by this extraordinary service, which seemed to increase the beauty and joy of the Deities. Followers still serve Govinda there in the proper way. Only when he had set the service on a firm footing did Rasikananda go out to preach.

How strictly he upheld the service of the Deity is shown by an incident that the “Rasika-mangala” calls “The curse for an offence against Krishna's service.” Once Shyamadasi, while cooking the bhoga, left the cooking to feed her firstborn, Vrajananda, who was crying with hunger. Rasika, seeing that the offering was delayed, grew angry: “You have abandoned the service of Krishna, the Lord of life, and, deluded by maya, taken a son on your lap. If Krishna's service is broken for even a moment, not one of your sons will remain with you; only the one you raise without offence will remain on earth.” By that word, the poet writes, six sons died one year after another; Shyamadasi grieved, and then by the Prabhu's mercy three were spared — Radhananda, Krishnagati and Radha-Krishna Dasa, faultless in their service to guru, Krishna and the sadhus.[14]

Preaching

The fame of his preaching lives on in the villages of Orissa to this day. At the end of the sixteenth and the beginning of the seventeenth century, the preaching of Gaudiya dharma by Shyamananda and Rasikananda-Murari transformed the entire district of Balasore. At his guru's command Rasikananda carried the message of Sri Gaurachandra for nearly forty-six years, and through him many agnostics and unbelievers became devotees of Gaura and Nityananda. “Give everyone the sixteen names of ‘Hare Krishna,’” Shyamananda told him, “brahmana and shudra, chandala and pukkasa, king and subject; go yourself from house to house.” From that day Rasika began to give initiation; among his first ten disciples were Kalindi and a yavana named Bhaktadasa.

The first field of his preaching was Dharenda. It was ruled by two brothers, Bhima and Shrikara, of the gopa caste — wealthy and arrogant: they sacrificed goats and buffaloes and mocked the Vaishnavas. Rasika stayed with their daughter's sons, Rasamaya and Vamshi, and there met the kirtana singer Tulasi Dasa, who from then on was always at his side; all night he had Tulasi sing one and the same pada, and wept. Then he came to the brothers' assembly. “You are only twenty years old,” Bhima railed at him, “so why, boy, have you become a Vaishnava? In the line of Achyuta, ruler of Mallabhumi, such a son is born — you will go begging from door to door!” Rasika with a smile proposed a debate with their pandits on all the scriptures, and not one could answer him; then the brothers with their whole family took his shelter and gave up the killing of animals, and Dharenda, says the poet, became “like Vraja.” If Bhima gave his age correctly, this was about 1610. Later Sri Hridayananda came to Dharenda, saw

Shyamananda, Rasika and Damodara, and charged them: “Give everyone in Utkala Chaitanya's prema-bhakti and the name ‘Hare Krishna’” — and showed Rasika much mercy.

Shyamananda empowered him so that he turned robbers, the godless, Muslims and other fallen souls to bhakti and gave all of them the jewel of prema. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (15.82–86) says: great was Rasikananda's influence; in his mercy he delivered many pashandis and gave the jewel of bhakti to the yavanas; with his disciples he wandered from village to village — and how many beings he delivered! Sri Rasikananda was ever intoxicated with sankirtana — and who, singing his virtues, would not be moved?[15] According to the “Rasika-mangala,” he honoured anyone who bore the marks of a Vaishnava, regardless of birth — even mlechchhas. The “Prema-vilasa” (19.91–92) also says that Rasikananda's greatness is boundless: he delivered many robber yavanas, and his disciples cannot be counted.

Once, when thirty Vaishnavas had come to him and there was no ghee to feed them, Rasika went at night into the house of a Mughal. The man struck him, and Rasika, smiling, took him by the hand: “Your hand will hurt against my hard body.” Within two or three days the Mughal's horses and elephants died, his goods were lost and his household lay at death's door; he came and surrendered to Rasika, who told him: “Go, serve Krishna and be kind to all beings — your wealth will return.” And so it happened.

It is told that once a wicked Muslim, wanting to silence him, set a maddened elephant upon him. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (15.84–85) tells it briefly: the elephant sent by the wicked man Rasikananda made his disciple and engaged in the service of Krishna and the Vaishnavas, and the wicked yavana raja himself bowed before him. The onlookers were amazed, and that man came to him and surrendered.[16] This was no display of power: it was the Lord's mercy at work and the power with which his guru had invested him.

In Vaishakha, at the full moon, Shyamananda and Rasika held a swing festival (Panchama-dola) at Barakola: the Deity Shyamaraya was brought from Dharenda, and rajas, bhunyas and the subadar of Medinipur himself came. There Vishvanatha Bhunya, brother of Raja Harichandana, a connoisseur of music and letters, asked Rasika for initiation; Rasika first sent him to Shyamananda, but Vishvanatha answered, “You are my lord.” Rasika gave him the mantra and the name Shyama-Manohara, and he, victorious in debate, went on to make disciples himself.

Kings, too, took shelter of him. His disciples included the Raja of Mayurbhanja (Orissa), Vaidyanatha Bhanja, drawn by his spiritual power; Ganapati, the zamindar of Patashpura (Medinipur); Bhima and Shrikara, the rulers of Dharenda; and Ahmad Beg, whose father-in-law Ibrahim Khan governed Orissa.[17] According to the “Rasika-mangala,” Rasika came alone, the “Bhagavata” in his hand, to Rajgarh, to Raja Vaidyanatha and his brothers; they washed his feet, and their pandits debated with him on Sankhya, Mimamsa, Yoga, Nyaya, Vaisheshika and Vedanta — he brought everything back to devotion to Krishna. He spoke to them of the jiva, of the rarity of human birth, of seeking shelter with one who is devoted to Krishna with his whole heart, whatever his birth, and of not accepting initiation from a non-Vaishnava, “even a brahmana learned in the Vedas.” Then he asked the three brothers for “one alms” — to give up the killing of living beings; the brothers accepted initiation, and “all of Bhanjabhum became Vaishnava.”

Once, during a reading of the “Bhagavata” in the assembly, the raja let his eyes stray to a dancing girl, and Rasika's disciple, the brahmana Ramakrishna, struck him across the face in anger: “Leaving the nectar of words about Krishna, you drink poison!” The courtiers reached for their swords, but the raja fell at Ramakrishna's feet, owned the punishment deserved and, taking his hand, said: “Your hand has been hurt against my hard body.” Then Rasika knew that the raja had become a true Vaishnava. Rasika was also with Shyamananda when he won over Uddhanda Raya, the bhunya of Nrisimhapura, who had

been robbing the Vaishnavas.

Writings

Rasikananda left several works. The chief of them is the “Shyamananda-shataka,” a life of his guru; later Baladeva Vidyabhushana wrote a commentary on it. Narahari Chakravarti quotes from it a verse that glorifies Shyamananda “as the beloved disciple of Hridayananda and as the dear disciple's disciple of Sri Subala, the Lord's friend” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1.381; he does not name the author). Also known are his “Bhakta-bhagavatashtaka” and “Kunjakeli-dvadashaka.”[18] Already in childhood and boyhood, according to the “Rasika-mangala,” he composed songs in various languages and shlokas in the manner of various kavyas.

Departure

Shortly before his departure, it is said, Rasikananda came with seven disciples to the village of Bansdaha (Vamshadaha) near Jaleshvara. Along this very road Mahaprabhu Himself had once travelled to Puri with Nityananda:

“Having spent the night in Jaleshvara, the Lord set out at dawn together with the devotees. On the way to Vamshadaha the Lord met a shakta sannyasi, who tried to instruct Mahaprabhu.” (CB, Antya 2.263–264)

From there Rasikananda and his companions went on to Remuna, singing the holy names all the way.[19]

In Remuna he spoke of Krishna with the devotees there and instructed everyone always to worship Him. When they entered the courtyard of the renowned temple of Kshirachora-Gopinatha, Rasikananda approached the Lord, touched His lotus feet — and disappeared into the Deity of Gopinatha, entering the Lord's eternal pastimes at His feet.[20] His seven disciples left their bodies at once. In the temple courtyard of Kshirachora-Gopinatha the pushpa-samadhi (flower samadhi) of Rasika-Murari and his seven companions is honoured to this day.

This took place in 1652.[21] According to our calendar, the disappearance day of Srila Rasikananda Deva Gosvami is observed on Gaura-pratipad of the month of Govinda, two days after Shivaratri; in Remuna his departure is celebrated every year for twelve days.[22] Our calendar does not give the day of his appearance.

With Rasikananda's departure — together with those of Srinivasa, Narottama and Shyamananda — one biographer associates the beginning of the third of the four “dark periods” of Bengal Vaishnavism.

Family, Descendants and Successors

Rasikananda and Shyamadasi, according to the “Rasika-mangala,” had daughters — the elder, Devaki, a disciple of Shyamananda, and the gentle Vrindavati — and nine sons, of whom three survived: Radhananda, Krishnagati and Radha-Krishna Dasa. Radhananda Thakura, a beloved disciple of Shyamananda, was versed in all the scriptures and renowned as a master of music.[23] Descendants of Rasikananda live to this day in Gopivallabhapura (Gopijana-vallabhapura). His preaching was carried on by his son Radhananda, his grandson Nayanananda and others. Among his descendants was also Vishvambharananda Deva Gosvami, author of the well-known “Astikya-darshana.”

At Sripat Gopivallabhapura Vishvambharananda kept a collection of old manuscripts — among them copies of Srila Rupa Gosvami's works and records of the Gosvamis' dates; in February 1925, following the direction of their gurus, Vaishnavas searched for manuscripts there together with him — so the author of one biography recalls.

Through Rasikananda runs the disciplic succession of Baladeva Vidyabhushana in the line of Nityananda: Gauridasa Pandita — Hridaya Chaitanya — Shyamananda — Rasikananda — Nayanananda — Radha-Damodara — Baladeva. Nayanananda was Baladeva's parama-guru, while his direct guru was Sri Radha-Damodara, then head of the “Shyamasundara-kunja” matha founded by Shyamananda in Vrindavana (“Siddhanta-ratna,” commentary on 8.35).[24]

Significance

Rasikananda is the model of a disciple who gave his whole being to his guru and so became the channel of his power. His prayer brought his guru to him, and his service to Govinda and tireless preaching turned an entire region to Gaura and Nityananda — from forest villages to royal courts. Narahari Chakravarti sings of him in a song: the merciful Rasika-Murari destroys the defilement of Kali, his spotless virtues captivate all hearts, his mind rests at Shyamananda's feet, all his rasa is Gaurachandra, and his fame fills the three worlds; “there is no end to the deeds of Sri Rasikananda; he is ever beside himself with the virtues of Prabhu Shyamananda” (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 15.87–91). One biographer suggests that in Krishna's eternal pastimes he serves as a manjari — but this is only the author's conjecture, not based on the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika.”

1. Only the first volume of the “Rasika-mangala” — the Purva and Dakshina vibhagas — has come down to us; the second, which apparently tells of his later years and departure, has not been found. Hence what the first volume does not mention (Rasikananda's dream, the elephant, the royal disciples of Patashpura and Mayana, Ahmad Beg, his writings, his departure in Remuna and so on) is given here from other sources, without checking against the poem.

2. The “Prema-vilasa” (19.88; 20.190–193) speaks of the raja's two sons, Rasika and Murari, and names among Shyamananda's chief branches two disciples from Rayani, Rasikananda and Murari, as different persons, each with his own wife; they also appear separately, “Rasikananda, Sri Murari,” in the list of Shyamananda's closest disciples in one biography. Narahari Chakravarti in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” states clearly that they are one person; so does the “Rasika-mangala.”

3. According to one biography, he was born on the 18th of Kartika, on the night of Divali, and the village lies in the district of Medinipur, where the Suvarnarekha meets the Dolanga. By our calculation the new moon of Dipavali in 1590 fell on Sunday, 28 October, so that a birth “in the third watch of the night” falls in the night of 28–29 October 1590; the positions of the Sun, Moon, Mars, Jupiter, Venus and Saturn in the poem's horoscope agree with this date, as does the eighteenth day of Tula (to within a day or two). In our calendar this is the night of Dipavali — the amavasya of the month of Damodara, on the eve of Gaura-pratipad; the calendar does not give Rasikananda's appearance day.

4. According to one biography, the raja had long been without a son and regarded his only child as a jewel granted by the mercy of the Lord of the universe, Lord Jagannatha.

5. The “Prema-vilasa” (20.191) calls Rasikananda and Murari “two brahmanas”; the passage belongs to the late part of that book. The “Rasika-mangala,” describing how zealously Achyuta served the brahmanas, remarks that everyone praised him, “calling him a brahmana” — praise of his piety, not a statement of caste.

6. According to one biography, his wife was Ichchhamayi Devi (Ichchhadei), a native of Ghatshila, and he met his guru in her home village; the “Bhakti-ratnakara” does not say where she came from, while the “Rasika-mangala” names Hijli as her home. The “Prema-vilasa” (20.192) names the wives of Rasikananda and Murari as Malati and Shachirani.

7. So the poem has it: Shyamananda is one of Krishna's eternal beloved companions in Vraja, appearing in the form of His devotee; these words concern the eternal pastimes of Radha and Krishna and have nothing in common with worldly sentiment. The same image appears in the vision of the yogi Damodara, told below.

8. The biographies tell this in their own ways. In one, Rasikananda went off alone to meditate and sank into deep trance; the voice called him by name, told him not to worry, named Shyamananda as his guru whom he would soon meet in that very place, and promised that in his shelter his life would reach its goal; then he wept all night, chanting Shyamananda's name on his beads, and in the dream Shyamananda told him not to worry, for they would meet that same day. In another, the voice calls him “Rasikananda!” and calls Shyamananda a mahabhagavata, or bids him go to him for initiation without delay — and Rasikananda sets out at once, while Shyamananda comes to Rohini, to his house, on his way from Dharenda-Bahadurpura. A third adds that Ghatshila is now in Bihar (in the present division, in the state of Jharkhand).

9. The guru's anger here is no worldly outburst: in this way Shyamananda tests his disciple and shows him mercy, and Rasikananda himself receives the blows as release from karma. Why the guru was angry the edition does not say — the line is lost.

10. According to the biographies, Damodara was initiated in Rayani (Rohini).

11. If Rasikananda was born in 1590, his presence at the Kheturi festival would require a very late dating of the festival itself; the question remains open. The first volume of the “Rasika-mangala” does not mention Kheturi.

12. This does not diminish Krishna: the Lord Himself places service to His devotee above service to Himself. “Of all kinds of worship, the worship of Vishnu is the highest, but higher even than that is the service of His devotee, the Vaishnava” (“Padma Purana”; quoted in CC, Madhya 11.31). And the poet himself says of Rasika that he served guru, Krishna and the Vaishnavas as non-different.

13. According to one biography, Shyamananda handed him the service of Govinda only as he was leaving the world; the “Bhakti-ratnakara” and the “Prema-vilasa” do not say when, and in the first volume of the “Rasika-mangala” the manifestation of Govinda in Gopivallabhapura is only foretold.

14. So the author of the poem, who wrote in Rasikananda's own circle, relates it; we give his words exactly. In his telling this is strictness in the service of the Deity: for Rasikananda, Krishna's service stood above every attachment, even to his own child. The anger of a pure devotee is not worldly anger: it does not arise from selfishness and is directed only at what interrupts the service of Krishna; and the sons who lived were those who served without fault.

15. One biography, citing the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” renders this passage more fully: robbers, blasphemers, demons and unbelievers, yavanas and outcastes were delivered; the homes he visited were past counting; in nama-sankirtana he seemed all but mad. These details are not in the Bengali text of the “Bhakti-ratnakara.”

16. According to one biography, he set the elephant to serve Vishnu and His devotees. Another, citing the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” says that forest elephants became his disciples and were moved to sing the name of Gopala-Krishna, and that tigers, turned from their predatory nature, were drawn by him to devotion to Krishna; this is not in the “Bhakti-ratnakara.”

17. According to another biography, the Raja of Patashpura was Gajapati; it adds the Raja of Mayana, Chandrabhanu, and calls Bhima, Shrikara and the yavana “Suva Ahmad” (apparently a subadar) wicked men and unbelievers who abandoned their wicked ways and sought his shelter.

18. According to another biography, the second book is the “Shrimad-bhagavata-ashtaka”; it also mentions various collections of his verses, prayers and songs.

19. According to another biography, he came to Remuna from Sarata-grama; it does not mention the seven disciples.

20. A pure devotee does not “dissolve” in the Deity or lose his identity: he only withdraws from the eyes of the world and continues to serve the Lord in His eternal pastimes.

21. According to one biography, it was the year 1578 of the Shaka era, equated with 1652; but 1578 Shaka corresponds to about 1656, and 1652 to 1574 Shaka.

22. According to one biography, the festival in Remuna falls on Shiva-chaturdashi of the month of Magha.

23. According to one biography, the sons were named Radhananda, Krishna-Govinda and Radha-Krishna.

24. According to one biography, Pandita Radha-Damodara, Baladeva's teacher in Puri, ranked among the chief disciples of Rasikananda himself.